Ethics in Real Life

Analyzing Privacy and Security Case Studies Through Multiple Ethical Lenses

Topics 5 & 6 (Privacy & Security)

Ho Chi Minh City University of Science

Today's Cases

1. **The 2026 AI Defense Dispute:** Anthropic, OpenAI, and the Pentagon's clash over mass surveillance and security.
2. **The Internet Worm (1988):** Robert Tappan Morris Jr. and the first major denial-of-service attack.

Case 1: Anthropic, OpenAI & The Pentagon (2026)

Scenario

In early 2026, the U.S. Pentagon requested to deploy commercial AI models on classified networks. **Anthropic** refused the contract, demanding strict prohibitions against using their AI for **domestic mass surveillance** and **fully autonomous lethal weapons**.

The Outcome

- The Pentagon rejected the limitations, banning federal use of Anthropic and designating them a "supply-chain risk."
- Hours later, **OpenAI** signed a massive deal to deploy their models to the Pentagon, agreeing to the government's terms while claiming they would implement their own technical safeguards.

Case 1: Ethical & Legal Analysis

- **Kantianism:** Anthropic acted on a categorical imperative—refusing to treat human lives and privacy merely as tools for military or surveillance efficiency. OpenAI's approach could be viewed as treating ethical boundaries as flexible for competitive gain.
- **Utilitarianism:** *Split.* OpenAI argues that securing the nation's defense with top AI maximizes overall public safety. Anthropic argues the long-term harms of normalized mass surveillance and autonomous weapons far outweigh short-term defense utility.

- **Social Contract:** Anthropic's refusal defends civil liberties and the privacy rights of citizens against potential government overreach.
- **Virtue Ethics:** Anthropic exhibited courage and integrity by sacrificing massive financial gain for principles.

Case 2: The Internet Worm (1988)

Scenario

Robert Tappan Morris, Jr., a graduate student at Cornell, released a self-contained worm onto the Internet from an MIT computer.

The Issue

- **Massive Disruption:** The worm exploited security holes in networked computers and spread to 6,000 Unix computers. Infected computers kept crashing or became unresponsive.
- **Consequences:** Morris was suspended from Cornell. He received 3 years' probation, 400 hours of community service, and $150,000 in legal fees and fines.

Case 2: Ethical & Legal Analysis

- **Kantianism (FAIL):** Morris used others by gaining access to their computers without permission.
- **Social Contract (FAIL):** Morris violated the property rights of organizations.
- **Utilitarianism (SPLIT/FAIL):**
  - *Benefits:* Organizations learned of security flaws.
  - *Harms:* Time spent fighting the worm, unavailable computers, and disrupted network traffic.

Verdict: Morris was wrong to have released the Internet worm.

Theory Comparison

Theory	Case 1: Pentagon & AI (Privacy/Security)	Case 2: The Internet Worm (Security)
Kantianism	**Split** (Principles vs. Pragmatism)	**Wrong**
Social Contract	**Tension** (National Security vs. Civil Liberties)	**Wrong**
Virtue Ethics	**Split** (Integrity vs. Opportunism)	**Wrong**
Utilitarianism	**Contested** (Defense vs. Surveillance Risk)	**Split**

Conclusion & Key Takeaways

1. **Privacy vs. Security:** The Pentagon AI case demonstrates the modern struggle between leveraging technology for national defense and protecting fundamental privacy rights against mass surveillance.
2. **Respecting Resources:** In the Morris Worm case, the unauthorized access and disruption of computers constituted a severe ethical failure, highlighting that using others' systems without permission is wrong.
3. **Corporate Responsibility:** Tech companies must actively decide whether to enforce ethical red lines (like Anthropic) or adapt to government frameworks for deployment (like OpenAI).

THANK YOU FOR LISTENING